

JATLAND VISION Union ministers Dharmendra Pradhan and M.L. Khattar with Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini (left) in Rohtak, Jun. 23



Photographs by ANI

THE VALLEY OUTREACH RSS leader Ram Madhav (middle) in Srinagar in 2019 in his earlier avatar as a BJP national general secretary

the party has not 'projected' any of its tribal satraps, including ex-CMs Babulal Marandi and Arjun Munda. August saw a rash of turncoats entering the party, including former CM and Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM) veteran Champai Soren, which may complicate matters at the top. The BJP had already imported Geeta Koda, wife of coal scam accused ex-CM Madhu Koda, as well as Sita Soren, CM Hemant's sister-in-law, before the general election. The presence of the Kodas has made several state BJP leaders uneasy. The influx of Champai and the others has also reduced the space for former Union minister Arjun Munda, who is looking for ways to re-enter state politics.

The Enforcement Directorate's arrest of CM Soren and his subsequent bail have led to a sympathy wave in favour of the JMM leader, further weakening the BJP's tribal game plan in the state. Twenty-eight out of the 81 seats in the state assembly are reserved for tribals, and the pattern so far has been that whoever takes them wins the state.

REINVENTING THE BJP

The BJP's biggest advantage is its ability to change and reinvent. Down it may be, but never out. The party has done it in the past. The setback of the general election has sufficiently impressed upon the party top brass that it has to carry along the RSS, which is the real backbone of the party, especially while considering the big political, economic and social reforms. This means consulting them on appointing state unit chiefs, picking new chief ministers, key ministers, building on election campaigns and before inducting turncoats (especially those with stated anti-Sangh antecedents). It also has to undo the impression that it uses central agencies to fix opponents and engineer defections, something that has not helped the party's image at all. While the churn has already led to a rethink and change in approach, the proof will come with the choice of the new national president and the expected overhaul of the national team.

In the past decade, the perception was that most decision-making in the party was centralised and confined to a handful of trusted favourites. Also, that states are run, as one senior party leader put it, by a "few bureaucrats controlled by Delhi", with the state political leadership being only a "caretaker". All this has exacted a huge political cost. Insiders say the party now needs to work out strategies to allow space for local leaders to work, perform and grow, be it CMs or state unit chiefs. There is a lot of pressure on the BJP leadership to reboot the top decision-making bodies, including the parliamentary board and central election committees. Rather than just be pro forma bodies filled with lightweights, the push is now to have powerful central and state leaders who can weigh in on decisions.

To its credit, the BJP has in the past decade been able to transform itself from a party perceived as being led by Brahmins and Baniyas to one that accommodates all communities and their interests under a larger Hindutva banner. But the issue of reservations and caste census, which gave the Opposition plenty of traction, has come as a setback for the BJP, especially in the heartland states. The party now needs to work out a national strategy to curtail the damage this may have wreaked on its rainbow coalition of OBC parties and its Dalit outreach. The RSS and several insiders also believe that the party needs to adopt a more balanced and nuanced approach towards the minorities while pushing the Hindutva agenda. One way to do this would be to hold more consultations, especially with the moderates among the minorities, including on issues such as the implementation of a uniform civil code or the curtailing of the Waqf Board's powers and other crucial reforms.

In the meantime, the party is concentrating its energies on the four states heading for polls. After all, its performance in the state elections will indicate whether the party has learnt its lessons or is still stuck in the *chakravyuh* it finds itself in. ■